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barnaby rudge marks this epoch because it marks the fact that he is still confused about what kind of person he is going to be he has already struck the note of the normal romance in nicholas nickleby he has already created some of his highest comic characters in pickwick and the old curiosity shop but here he betrays the fact that it is still a question what ultimate guide he shall follow barnaby rudge is a romantic historical novel its design reminds us of scott some parts of its fulfilment remind us alas of harrison ainsworth it is a very fine romantic historical novel scott would have been proud of it but it is still so far different from the general work of dickens that it is permissible to wonder how far dickens was proud of it the book effective as it is is almost entirely devoted to dealings with a certain artistic element which in its mere isolation dickens did not commonly affect an element which many men of infinitely less genius have often seemed to affect more successfully i mean the element of the picturesque

gilbert keith chesterton

appreciations and criticisms of the works of charles dickens